History of Tamil Society

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Introduction

✔ Tamil culture emerged even before the 3rd century BCE. Tamil merchants maintained trade and cultural relations with foreign countries through maritime routes.

✔ Foreign contacts, domestic production, and ways of life together contributed to the development of cities, ports, and the circulation of currency in Tamil Nadu.

✔ The Tamil language was first written using the 'Tamil-Brahmi' script; documents were created; and classical Tamil poetic works were composed.

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Evidence on early Tamil society

Classical Tamil Literatures

- Sangam Literatures
- Tolkappiyam
- Pathinenmelkanakku
- Pathinenkilkanakku
- Social Life, Traditions, and Relationships

Inscriptions

- Ashoka's Brahmi inscriptions
- Pandya, Chola, Chera inscriptions
- Information on taxes, education, religion

Archaeological Evidences

- Excavations
- Pottery, metal objects.
- Evidence on settlement structure, industry, trade

Foreign literary references

- Books written by Periplus, Pliny, and Ptolemy
- Accounts of Chinese traveler Xuanzang and Megasthenes
- Tamil Nadu's trade relations, cities, and economy

Epigraphical Evidence

- Inscriptions engraved on objects such as stone inscriptions, copper plates, coins, and rings contain archaeological information; the study of these is called epigraphy.
- The earliest script used in Tamil Nadu is Tamil-Brahmi, which is found in cave dwellings, rock surfaces, terracotta objects, and coins.
- Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions found in places like Mangulam, Muthupatti, and Pugalur contain information related to the dwelling places of Jain monks.

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Classical Tamil Literature

1. Tholkappiyam

- Composed by Tholkappiyar
- Ancient grammar book

3 parts:

- Language grammar – 2 parts
- Social life grammar – 1 part

2. Sangam Literatures

Pathinenmelkanakku Texts

- **Ettuthogai (Eight Anthologies):** Narrinai, Kurunthogai, Akananuru, Purananuru, Ainkurunuru, Paripatal, Kalittokai, Patirruppattu
- **Pattuppattu (Ten Idylls):** Thirumurugatrupadai, Porunararruppadai, Sirupanarruppadai, Perumpanarruppadai, Mullai Pattu, Madurai Kanchi, Kurinjipattu, Netunalvatai, Pattinappalai, Malaipatukatam

3. Pathinenkilkanakku Texts (Eighteen Lesser Texts)
Texts on Ethics and Way of Life
Most Important Work: *Thirukkural*

- Composed in **Kural couplets** (short, aphoristic verses)
- Divided into three sections:
  - **Aram** (Virtue)
  - **Porul** (Wealth)
  - **Inbam** (Love/Pleasure)

4. The Five Great Epics of Tamil Literature (*Aimperum Kappiyangal*)

Epics are long literary works composed in poetic form with aesthetic elegance. They include:

- **Silappathikaram** (*The Tale of the Anklet*)
- **Manimekalai**
- **Seevaga Sinthamani**
- **Valayapathi**
- **Kundalakesi**

Sangam Age

Title	Details
Inscriptions	In the towns of Mangulam, Alagarmalai, and Keezhavalavalu
Copper Plate Inscriptions	Velvikudi and Chinnamanur
Megalithic Memorial Structures	Burial sites, headstones
Locations of archaeological evidence	Adichanallur, Arikamedu, Kodumanal, Puhar, Korkai, Alagankalam, Uraiyur
Notes from Foreigners	Hadikumba Inscription (Kalinga King Karavelan), Ashoka's Edicts (2, 13), Puli's Natural History, Ptolemy's Geography, Megasthenes, Rajavali, Mahavamsa, Dipavamsa
Literary evidence	Tholkappiyam, Ettutogai, Pathuppattu, Patinkeezhakanakku, Pattinappalai, Maduraikanchi, Silappathikaram, Manimegalai
Duration	From the 3rd century BC to the 3rd century AD
Geographical extend	From Vengadam (Tirupathi) in the north to Kanyakumari in the south; East & West: Sea Boundaries
Age	Iron Age
Culture	Megalithic culture
Government system	Monarchy
Kingdoms that ruled	Cheras, Cholas, Pandyas

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Cheras

- **Territorial Rule and Introduction:** During the Sangam period, the **Cheras** ruled over the western parts of Tamil Nadu, including **central and northern Travancore, Kochi, southern Malabar, and the Kongu region**. The term **"Vendhar"** is a common title used to refer to the three major Tamil dynasties: **Cheras, Cholas, and Pandyas**.
- **Chera Senguttuvan and Cultural Contributions:** Chera king **Senguttuvan** led a military expedition as far as **North India** and brought back stone from the **Himalayas** to install a statue for **Kannagi**. He introduced the **worship of the Pattini deity** (goddess of chastity). **Ilango Adigal**, the younger brother of Senguttuvan, authored the famous Tamil epic **Silappadikaram**.
- **Coins and Symbols:** A Chera king named **Cheral Irumporai** issued coins in his name. Some coins bear the **Chera emblem** — a **bow and arrow**.

Cholas

- The **Chola rule extended up to the Venkata Hills** (present-day Tirupati region).
- The **Kaveri delta** was the central region of the Chola country.

Karikalan – The Famous Chola King:

- **Karikalan** defeated the **Cheras, Pandyas,** and **11 Velir chieftains** in the **Battle of Venni**.
- He promoted **agriculture** by **converting forests into cultivable lands**.

Trade and Infrastructure:

- He built the **Kallanai (Grand Anicut)** across the **Kaveri River**, one of the oldest water-regulation structures still in use.
- The **port city of Puhar** (also known as **Kaveripattinam**) played a key role in **Indian Ocean trade** during the Chola period.

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Moovendar	Garland	the Capitals	Sea Ports
Cheras	Flower of Palm	Vanji / Karur	Musiri / Tondi
Cholas	Fig flower garland	Uraiyur / Puhar	Puhar
Pandiyas	Neem flower garland	Madurai	Korkai

Pandyas

- The **Pandyas ruled over southern Tamil Nadu**.
- They **patronized Tamil poets and scholars**, and many are mentioned in the **Sangam literature**.

Famous Kings:

- **Nedunchezhiyan** defeated the **Cheras, Cholas, and 5 Velir chieftains** at **Talaiyalankanam**.
- He was praised as the **"Lord of Korkai"** (an ancient Pandya port city).

Coins and Symbols:

- Issued coins bearing **elephant** and **fish** symbols.
- Royal emblems included the **Sengol (royal sceptre), Murasu (drum),** and the **white parasol (Venkottrakkudai)**.

Kurunila Mannargal (Minor Chieftains):

- Divided into three types: **Aayi**, **Velir**, and **Kizhar**.
- **Aayi** comes from Aayar (cowherds/herdsmen).

Notable Aayi Kings:

- **Andhiran**, **Thithiyan**, **Nannan**

Famous Velir Chiefs – the "Kadaiyezhu Vallalgal" (Last Seven Great Patrons):

- **Pari, Kari, Ori, Began, Aayi, Adhiyaman, Nalli**
  → Celebrated for their **generosity and support to Tamil poets**.
- **Kizhar** refers to **village chiefs**.

Political System of Sangam Age



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King = final court
King is the supreme court of appeal
Courts in the capital = courts
In villages = councils

Local Government
Administrative Division: Region → Country → State → Town
Towns = Perur, Chittur, Mudur

Types of cities
Coastal city = Pattinam
Port city = Puhar

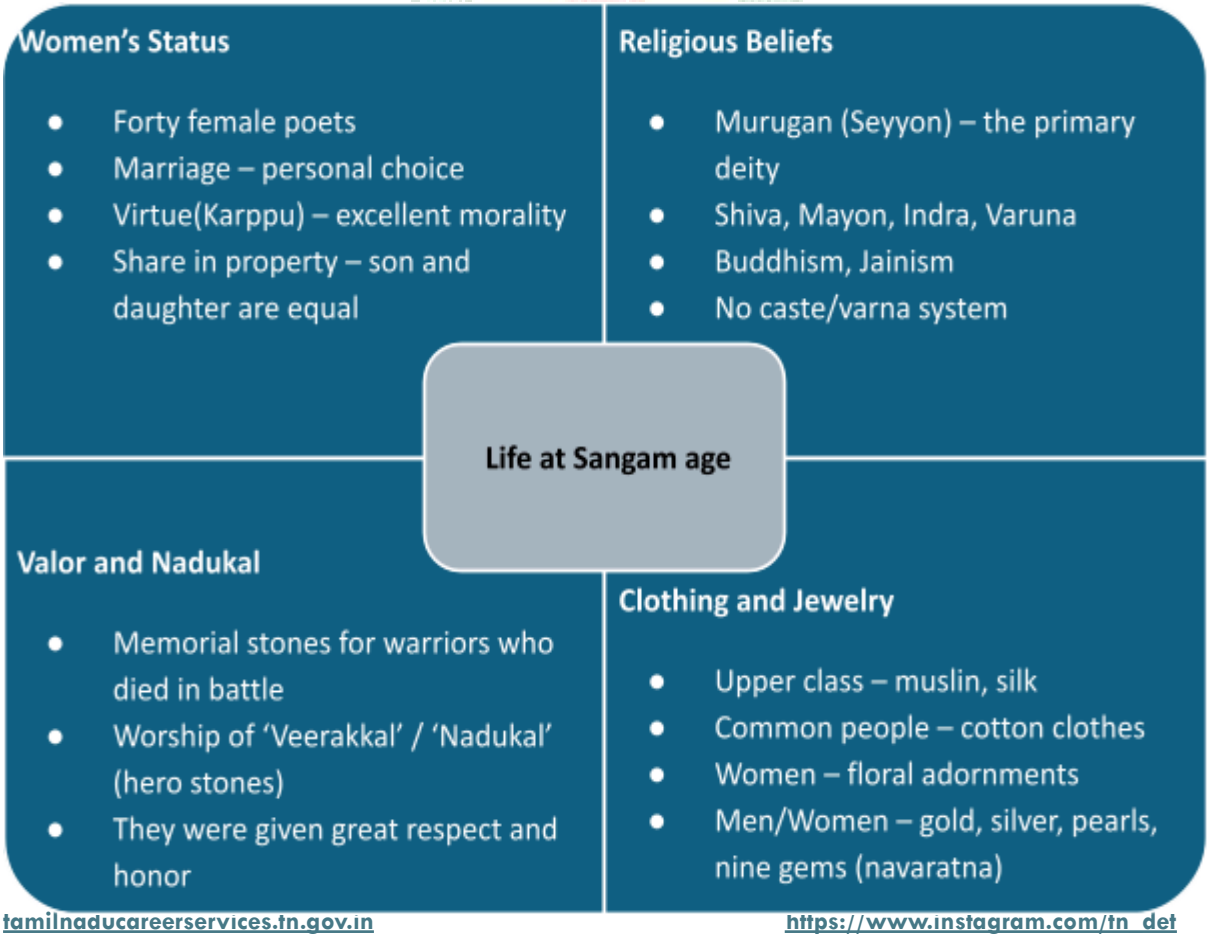
Organizations for Social Justice
Guidelines for People's Justice in Councils and Forums
Providing Local Government Solutions in Village Administration

Important Cities (Sangam Period)
Puhar – Port city
Uraiyur – Important seat of government
Korkai – Port for trade links across India
Madurai – Literary centre where Sangam poets gathered
Musiri – Commercial city
Vanchi (Karur) – Capital of the Chera kingdom
Kanchi – Centre of education and culture

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Thinai	Land	Occupation	People	God
Kurinji	Mountain and Mountainous	Hunting/Gathering	Kuravar, Kurathiyar	Murugan
Mullai	Forest and forest based	Livestock grazing	Aayar, Aaycciyar	Mayon (Krishna)
Marutham	Field and field based	Agriculture	Uzhavar, Uzhaththiyar	Indiran
Neithal	Sea and sea based	Fishing / Salt Production	Parathavar, Nulaththiyar	Varunan
Palai	Sand and sandy	---	Maravar, Maraththiyar	Kotravai



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- Agriculture, animal herding, fishing
- Weaving – part-time/full-time occupation
- Carpenter, blacksmith, potter
- Festivals – Pongal, Karthigai, Indira festival

Sports and Entertainment
- Dance
- Bullfighting
- Cockfighting
- Dhayam
- Hunting
- Wrestling (Malyutham)
- Swing
- Puppet cart
- Building sand houses

Arts and Culture
- Music instruments – Murasu (drum), Yazh (harp), Pullanguzhal (flute)
- Panar, Viraliyar – singing
- Kanigaiyar – dancing
- Tamil literature – poetry, music, drama
- Koothu- Folk Drama

Markets
- Madurai
- Nalangadi – morning
- Allangadi – evening
- Puhar

In the markets:
- Salt, pepper, pearls, cotton cloth, silk, perfumes, diamonds, sandalwood

Foreign Trade
- Ports: Muziris, Thondi, Korkai
- Export items:
  - Salt
  - Pepper
  - Pearls
  - Silk
  - Diamonds
  - Kumkum flowers
  - Muslin

Kalabhra Rule

1. **Rule & Sources**
   - Ruled for about 2.5 centuries, starting from the end of the 3rd century CE
   - Limited archaeological evidence; literary sources include *Navalar Sarithai*, *Yaapperungalam*, *Periya Puranam*
2. **Religion, Language & Script Development**
   - Growth of Buddhism and Jainism
   - Introduction of Sanskrit and Prakrit
   - Development of Vatteluttu (rounded script)

Import Items:
- Topaz (Pushparagam)
- Lead
- Grape wine
- Glass
- Horses

Trade Relations:
- Greece, Rome, Egypt, China, Southeast Asia, Sri Lanka

Archaeological Evidence:
- Black pepper found in the body of Ramses (Egyptian Pharaoh)
- Roman papyrus agreement
- Musuri– India's first major emporium (international trade center)

Handicrafts
- Glass beads
- Various colors and shapes
- Kudikkadu – industrial site
- Substitutes for navaratna (nine gems)
- Pearl and conch shell bangles
- Pearl cleansing (evidenced in Keezhadi excavation)
- Conch shells collected at Pamban
- Beautifully cut and shaped into bangles
- Worn by ancient women

Agriculture
- Major livelihood sector

Crops:
- Paddy (red rice, white rice, five-grain rice)
- Sugarcane
- Millets

Irrigation:
- Wetland farming – river-fed irrigation
- Dryland farming – arid regions

Shifting cultivation = Punam

Excavation Evidence:
- Adichanallur
- Porunthal
- Discovery of paddy and storage jars (taazhi)

Literature & Script
- Growth of Tamil literature
- Sanskrit and Prakrit languages
- Development of the Vatteluttu script
- *Pathinenkilkanakku*
- Buddhist and Jain contributions